

THE HR GENERALIST CAREER PLAYBOOK

A practical roadmap to building a versatile, future-ready HR career

By Your Next Door HR

PAGE 1 — BEFORE WE START

“HR Generalist has no growth?”

I hear this a lot.

And honestly, the problem isn't being an HR Generalist.

The problem is staying a **basic Generalist** for years without building depth.

An HR Generalist can get exposure to almost every part of HR:

Recruitment + HR Operations + Payroll + Employee Relations + Performance + Engagement + L&D + Compliance

That breadth can become your biggest career advantage.

But only if you intentionally build **depth + business understanding + specialised skills**.

This playbook will help you understand:

- What an HR Generalist should learn
 - What skills to build at every career stage
 - Where to learn them
 - What HR tools you should know
 - When to specialise
 - How to move towards HRBP/Manager roles
 - How to demonstrate your impact
 - How to future-proof your HR career
-

PAGE 2 — WHAT DOES AN HR GENERALIST ACTUALLY DO?

An HR Generalist connects multiple parts of the employee lifecycle.

Think:

TALENT ACQUISITION

Manpower requirement

↓

JD

↓

Sourcing

↓

Interview

↓

Selection

↓

Offer

↓

Joining

EMPLOYEE LIFECYCLE

Onboarding

↓

HR Operations

↓

Attendance & Leave

↓

Payroll

↓

Employee Relations

↓

Performance

↓

Engagement

↓

Career Development

↓

Exit

Your role may vary by organisation.

In a smaller company, you might handle **almost everything**.

In a larger company, you may partner with specialist teams.

That's why Generalist roles can give you an excellent **360° view of HR**.

PAGE 3 — THE 8 CORE AREAS YOU SHOULD KNOW

A strong HR Generalist should have working knowledge of:

01 — Recruitment

Sourcing, screening, interviewing and hiring.

02 — HR Operations

Employee lifecycle, documentation and HR processes.

03 — Payroll

Salary structures, payroll inputs and deductions.

04 — Compliance

Labour laws, statutory requirements and HR policies.

05 — Employee Relations

Grievances, conflicts and disciplinary matters.

06 — Performance Management

Goals, reviews, ratings and performance improvement.

07 — Learning & Development

Training needs, programmes and capability development.

08 — Engagement & Culture

Employee experience, engagement initiatives and communication.

You don't need to be an expert in all eight.

But you should understand **how they connect**.

PAGE 4 — IF YOU'RE A FRESHER, START HERE

Don't start by collecting 10 HR certifications.

Start by understanding **how HR works**.

Learn:

Employee Lifecycle

Offer → Joining → Onboarding → Employment → Performance → Development → Exit

HR Basics

- Recruitment
- HR Operations
- Payroll
- Compliance
- Performance
- Employee Relations
- Engagement

Tools

- Excel
- HRMS
- ATS
- Google Workspace / Microsoft Office

Where to learn

YouTube

Search practical HR topics rather than just "HR course."

Coursera

HR fundamentals + people management.

LinkedIn Learning

HR fundamentals + workplace skills.

SHRM

HR concepts and frameworks.

CIPD

HR profession and people practices.

Your goal:

Don't just understand HR terminology.

Understand **what HR actually does in a business.**

PAGE 5 — MASTER RECRUITMENT BASICS

Even if you eventually move away from recruitment, Generalists should understand hiring.

Learn:

- Manpower planning
- JD creation
- Sourcing
- Boolean search
- Screening
- Interview coordination
- Candidate experience
- Offer management
- Negotiation
- Joining
- Onboarding

Metrics to know:

Time to Hire

Time to Fill

Offer-to-Join Ratio

Source of Hire

Cost per Hire

Where to learn:

YouTube

LinkedIn Learning

Naukri learning resources

LinkedIn Talent Solutions resources

Coursera

Practice:

Take a JD.

Source 10 profiles.

Shortlist 5.

Explain **why** you selected them.

PAGE 6 — MASTER HR OPERATIONS

You should understand the complete employee lifecycle.

Learn:

- Employee documentation
- HRMS
- Attendance
- Leave

- Employee records
- Transfers
- Promotions
- Confirmation
- Exit processes
- Full & Final Settlement
- HR MIS

Tools to explore:

Workday

SAP SuccessFactors

Oracle HCM

Darwinbox

Keka

Zoho People

You don't need to master every HRMS.

Understand the **workflow**.

Where to learn:

Official vendor resources

YouTube demos

LinkedIn Learning

PAGE 7 — EXCEL IS NON-NEGOTIABLE

If you're an HR Generalist, Excel will probably remain part of your life.

At minimum learn:

BASIC

- Sorting
- Filtering
- Formatting
- Data validation

INTERMEDIATE

- XLOOKUP/VLOOKUP
- IF/IFS
- COUNTIF/COUNTIFS
- SUMIF/SUMIFS
- Date functions
- Conditional formatting

ADVANCED

- Pivot Tables
- Power Query
- Dashboards
- Data cleaning

WHERE TO LEARN

Microsoft Learn

ExcelJet

YouTube

Coursera

PRACTICE PROJECT

Create a dummy employee database.

Then build:

Headcount | Attrition | Attendance | Leave | Tenure | Department | Location

PAGE 8 — LEARN PAYROLL BASICS

You don't need to become a payroll specialist.

But you should understand what happens to an employee's salary.

Learn:

- CTC
- Gross salary
- Basic
- HRA
- Allowances
- Deductions
- PF
- ESI
- Professional Tax
- TDS
- Bonus
- Gratuity
- Payslips
- Full & Final Settlement

WHERE TO LEARN

EPFO — PF

ESIC — ESI

Income Tax Department — TDS

YouTube — practical payroll

ClearTax — tax concepts

PRACTICE

Take a fictional employee earning ₹8 LPA.

Create a basic salary structure.

Understand:

CTC → Gross → Deductions → Net Pay

You don't need to be a lawyer.

But you should know enough to identify when something requires deeper legal/compliance review.

Understand the basics of:

- PF
- ESI
- Gratuity
- Bonus
- Maternity benefits
- POSH
- Minimum wages
- Working hours
- Leave
- Employment documentation
- Full & Final Settlement

WHERE TO LEARN

Start with official sources:

EPFO

ESIC

Ministry of Labour & Employment

State Labour Departments

For additional learning:

SHRM | CIPD | iPleaders

 Labour laws can change and requirements can vary by state. Always verify the current position from official sources.

An HR Generalist should understand what happens after someone joins.

Learn:

- Goal setting
- KRAs
- KPIs
- OKRs
- Performance reviews
- Rating systems
- Calibration
- Performance Improvement Plans
- Manager capability

WHERE TO LEARN

LinkedIn Learning

Coursera

SHRM

CIPD

Harvard Business Review

PRACTICE

Take a fictional Sales team.

Create KPIs around:

Revenue | New Customers | Conversion | Retention | Productivity

Then ask:

Are these metrics actually connected to business goals?

PAGE 11 — EMPLOYEE RELATIONS

This is where your **people skills** become extremely important.

Learn to handle:

- Employee grievances
- Manager conflicts
- Workplace concerns
- Difficult conversations
- Disciplinary situations
- Performance issues
- Employee complaints

Your principles:

Listen → Understand → Document → Assess → Act → Follow Up

Don't immediately take sides.

Learn to separate:

Facts vs Assumptions vs Emotions

WHERE TO LEARN

LinkedIn Learning

Coursera

SHRM

CIPD

Harvard Business Review

PRACTICE

Take fictional employee cases.

Ask:

What are the facts?

What policy applies?

What are the risks?

Who needs to be involved?

What should HR recommend?

PAGE 12 — LEARNING & DEVELOPMENT

You don't need to become an L&D specialist.

But understand how organisations build capability.

Learn:

- Training Needs Analysis
- Skill gaps
- Learning programmes
- Training evaluation
- Leadership development
- Upskilling
- Reskilling

WHERE TO LEARN

LinkedIn Learning

Coursera

CIPD

SHRM

PRACTICE

Take a fictional team with a productivity problem.

Ask:

Is this actually a training problem?

If yes:

What skill is missing?

What intervention would help?

How will we measure whether it worked?

PAGE 13 — EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT ≠ EVENTS

This is an important distinction.

Engagement isn't just:

-  Birthdays
-  Festivals
-  Team lunches
-  Gifts

Those can be part of employee experience.

But engagement is about:

Trust + Leadership + Growth + Recognition + Fairness + Meaning + Communication

Learn:

- Engagement surveys
- Pulse surveys
- Employee feedback
- Action planning
- Recognition
- Communication
- Culture

WHERE TO LEARN

Gallup resources
CIPD
SHRM
LinkedIn Learning
HBR

PRACTICE

Take a fictional engagement survey.

Identify:

Top 3 issues → Root causes → Recommended actions → Success metrics

PAGE 14 — HR ANALYTICS

Don't become the person who only prepares HR reports.

Learn to interpret them.

Start with:

- Headcount
- Attrition
- Absenteeism
- Hiring
- Employee movement
- Tenure
- Diversity
- Cost
- Productivity

Learn in this order:

Excel → Power BI → HR Analytics → Data Storytelling

WHERE TO LEARN

Microsoft Learn — Excel & Power BI

Coursera — HR Analytics

LinkedIn Learning — People Analytics

YouTube — practical dashboards

PRACTICE

Build an HR dashboard.

Then ask:

“What action should management take based on this data?”

PAGE 15 — SHOULD YOU LEARN POWER BI?

Yes.

Especially if you want to move towards:

HRBP | HR Analytics | HR Manager | Strategic HR

Build dashboards around:



Headcount



Attrition



Hiring



Absenteeism



Workforce demographics



HR cost



Employee movement

But remember:

Watching Power BI tutorials isn't the same as knowing Power BI.

Build something.

PAGE 16 — AI FOR HR GENERALISTS

AI can help you become faster and more effective.

Use it for:

- JD creation
- Employee communication
- Policy drafts
- HR FAQs
- HR reports
- Data analysis

- Survey analysis
- Interview questions
- SOP creation
- Process improvement
- HR research
- Brainstorming

Tools to explore:

ChatGPT

Microsoft Copilot

Gemini

Power Automate

PRACTICE

Take one repetitive HR process.

Ask:

What can be automated?

Then map:

Current Process → Automation → Human Review → Final Output

 Never upload confidential employee information, salary data or personal documents into public AI tools.

PAGE 17 — 0-2 YEARS

Your goal:

EXPOSURE

Try to get exposure to as many HR functions as possible.

Build:

- ☐ Recruitment
- ☐ HR Operations
- ☐ Payroll basics
- ☐ Compliance
- ☐ Employee Relations
- ☐ Performance
- ☐ Engagement
- ☐ Excel
- ☐ HRMS

Don't worry about specialising too early.

First understand **what you enjoy and what you're good at.**

PAGE 18 — 2–5 YEARS

Now your question changes.

Not:

"What HR work can I do?"

But:

"Where do I want to build depth?"

Potential specialisations:

HRBP

Business + People + Strategy

HR Operations

Process + Employee Lifecycle

Talent Acquisition

Hiring + Talent Strategy

Payroll & C&B

Numbers + Compensation

HR Analytics

Data + Insights

L&D

Capability + Development

Employee Relations

People + Workplace Risk

HRIS

Technology + HR

Your Generalist experience gives you the foundation.

Now use it to **choose your direction.**

PAGE 19 — 5+ YEARS

At this stage, breadth alone isn't enough.

Build:

- Business acumen
- Workforce planning
- People analytics
- Organisation design
- Talent strategy
- Leadership development
- HR technology

- Change management
- HR transformation
- Strategic stakeholder management

Your thinking should evolve from:

"I manage HR activities."



"I solve people problems."



"I help the business make better people decisions."



PAGE 20 — BUSINESS ACUMEN

This is what separates a **good HR Generalist** from a **future HR leader**.

Understand:

- Revenue
- Costs
- Profitability
- Productivity
- Headcount cost
- Revenue per employee
- Business strategy
- Market conditions

WHERE TO LEARN

Coursera

LinkedIn Learning

Harvard Business Review

YouTube — Finance for non-finance professionals

PRACTICE

Read your company's annual report.

Ask:

How does the company make money?

What are its biggest costs?

Which functions drive revenue?

Where is the company growing?

What people challenges could affect growth?

PAGE 21 — STAKEHOLDER MANAGEMENT

As your career grows, your stakeholders will change.

You'll work with:

Employees → Managers → Business Heads → Leadership → Finance → Legal → IT → Vendors

Learn to:

- Influence without authority
- Handle disagreements
- Push back professionally
- Negotiate
- Communicate difficult decisions
- Build trust

Instead of:

"Policy doesn't allow this."

Try:

"Here's the policy constraint, here's the risk, and here are the options we can consider."

That's how you start becoming a business partner.

PAGE 22 — YOUR HR GENERALIST CAREER PATH

ONE POSSIBLE PATH

HR Intern / HR Trainee



HR Executive



Senior HR Executive



HR Generalist



Senior HR Generalist / HR Manager



HRBP / HR Manager



Senior HRBP / HR Leader



HR Head / CHRO

OR SPECIALISE

HR Generalist

↩ ↓ ↘

TA | HRBP | HRIS

Payroll | Analytics | L&D

ER | C&B | HR Transformation

Your career doesn't have to stay on one path.

PAGE 23 — YOUR CV SHOULD SHOW IMPACT

Don't write:

✗ "Handled recruitment."

Write:

✓ "Managed end-to-end recruitment for X positions across X functions."

Don't write:

✗ "Handled employee engagement."

Write:

✓ "Designed employee engagement initiatives for X employees, achieving X% participation."

Don't write:

✗ "Handled HR operations."

Write:

✓ "Managed HR operations for X employees across X locations."

Don't write:

✗ "Prepared HR MIS."

Write:

✔ "Automated monthly HR reporting using Excel/Power BI, reducing reporting time by X%."

Your CV should answer:

What did you own?

What problem did you solve?

What changed because of your work?

Can you prove the impact?

PAGE 24 — YOUR 90-DAY UPSKILLING PLAN

DAYS 1–30

BUILD THE FOUNDATION

- ☐ Employee lifecycle
- ☐ Recruitment basics
- ☐ HR Operations
- ☐ Payroll basics
- ☐ Compliance basics
- ☐ Excel

DAYS 31–60

BUILD DEPTH

- ☐ Performance Management
- ☐ Employee Relations
- ☐ Engagement
- ☐ L&D basics
- ☐ HR Analytics

- ☐ HRMS
-

DAYS 61–90

BUILD YOUR EDGE

- ☐ Power BI dashboard
 - ☐ HR process/SOP project
 - ☐ Employee engagement case study
 - ☐ Payroll calculation exercise
 - ☐ HR analytics project
 - ☐ AI workflow
 - ☐ Update CV with measurable achievements
-

PAGE 25 — HR GENERALIST SELF-CHECK

Can you:

- ☐ Explain the employee lifecycle?
- ☐ Conduct a basic recruitment cycle?
- ☐ Work with an HRMS?
- ☐ Build HR reports in Excel?
- ☐ Understand payroll?
- ☐ Explain basic HR compliance?
- ☐ Handle employee grievances?
- ☐ Support performance management?
- ☐ Design an engagement initiative?
- ☐ Analyse HR data?

- ☐ Understand business metrics?
- ☐ Handle difficult stakeholders?
- ☐ Quantify your HR impact?

If you answered **NO** to several:

Don't panic.

You now know exactly where your gaps are.

PAGE 26 — THE BIGGEST HR GENERALIST MISTAKE

Don't become a "jack of all HR, master of none."

Your breadth is your **starting advantage**.

But eventually, you need depth.

Think:

BREADTH

Know how different HR functions work.

DEPTH

Become genuinely strong in at least one or two areas.

BUSINESS

Understand what the organisation needs.

DATA

Use evidence to make decisions.

TECHNOLOGY

Use HR tech and AI to work smarter.

That's when a Generalist becomes **future-ready**.

PAGE 27 — FINAL WORD

Your first few years in HR are about **learning the functions**.

The next phase is about **connecting them**.

And eventually, your value comes from understanding:

People + Business + Data + Technology + Strategy

Don't just collect HR certifications.

Build skills.

Don't just build skills.

Apply them.

Don't just apply them.

Measure the outcome.

And don't just say:

"I have 7 years of HR experience."

Be able to say:

"Here are the problems I've solved, the processes I've improved, the decisions I've influenced and the business impact I've created."

Because your years of experience tell employers **how long you've worked**.

Your capabilities tell them **how valuable you can be.**

Your career doesn't grow because your years increase.

It grows because your capability increases.

— Your Next Door HR